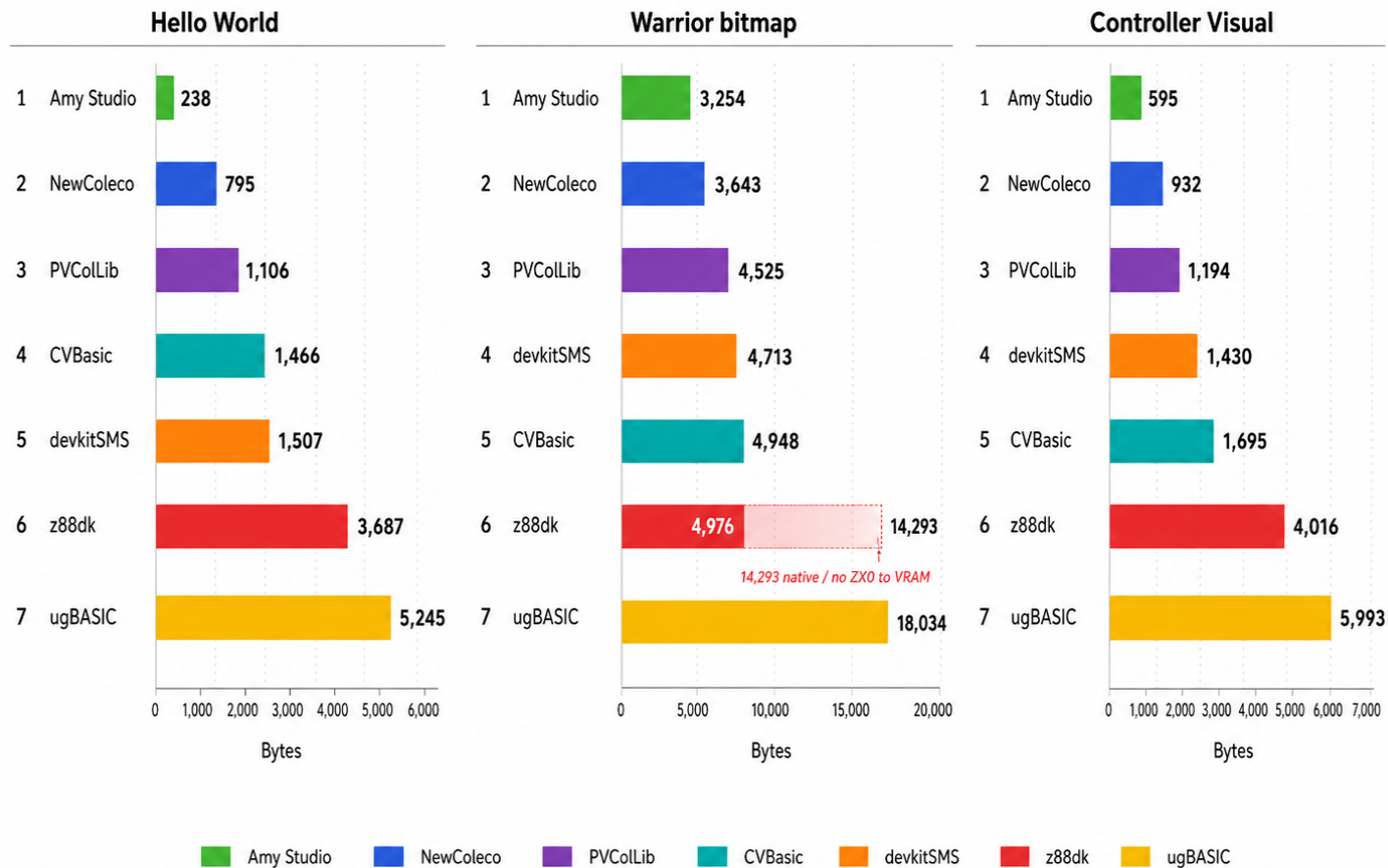


Amy Studio ColecoVision Toolchain Comparison

Measured results, capabilities, compression evidence, and development priorities

Real occupied size, excluding cartridge padding

sizes in bytes (lower is better)



Occupied ROM size excludes cartridge padding. Lower is smaller, not automatically faster or better.

Amy Studio source and GearColeco results

The compact listings are complete. The metasprite listing omits only its six pixel-pattern blocks, which remain in the evidence archive. Screenshots come from GearColeco 1.6.8 running each measured ROM for 180 NTSC frames.

Hello World

```
text screen  
backdrop sky blue  
print centered at 11, "HELLO, WORLD!"  
screen on
```



GearColeco screenshot

GearColeco output after 180 NTSC frames

Warrior Graphics II Bitmap

```
picture WarriorPicture:  
  pattern from "@project/warrior.pattern.zx0" codec zx0  
  color from "@project/warrior.color.zx0" codec zx0  
end picture  
  
show picture WarriorPicture
```



GearColeco screenshot

Exact GearColeco output; all seven tools reproduce the same target image

Visual Controller Input

```
text screen
backdrop dark blue
print centered at 8, "CONTROLLER TEST"
print centered at 11, "MOVE OR PRESS A BUTTON"
print centered at 14, "KEYPAD IS PURPLE"
screen on
```

```
InputLoop:
  wait
  if keypad(1) <> 255 then
    backdrop magenta
  elseif joypad(1).fire then
    backdrop light red
  elseif joypad(1).up then
    backdrop light green
  elseif joypad(1).down then
    backdrop dark green
  elseif joypad(1).left then
    backdrop light yellow
  elseif joypad(1).right then
    backdrop cyan
  else
    backdrop dark blue
  end if
  goto InputLoop
```



GearColeco screenshot

GearColeco output at the neutral controller state

Animated Three-Color Metasprite

```

u8 PlayerX = 120
u8 PlayerY = 88
u8 AnimationTick = 0
u8 AnimationFrame = 0

data PlayerMeta metasprite layers 3
  frame 0,15, 4,11, 8,1
  frame 12,15, 16,11, 20,1
end data

' Six 16x16 pattern blocks are included in the evidence archive.
sprites simple
set sprite count 3

MainLoop:
  wait
  if joypad(1).left and PlayerX > 1 then PlayerX -= 1
  if joypad(1).right and PlayerX < 239 then PlayerX += 1
  if joypad(1).up and PlayerY > 1 then PlayerY -= 1
  if joypad(1).down and PlayerY < 175 then PlayerY += 1
  AnimationTick += 1
  if AnimationTick = 8 then
    AnimationTick = 0
    AnimationFrame = 1 - AnimationFrame
  end if
  set metasprite PlayerMeta frame AnimationFrame to PlayerY,PlayerX using sprite 0
  update sprites
  goto MainLoop

```



GearColeco screenshot

A metasprite is one visual actor assembled here from three overlapping hardware sprites

Graphics II compression corpus

All 46 unique 12,288-byte pictures passed exact round-trip checks with every codec. The gallery shows the actual TMS9918 output; the percentage is each picture's smallest compressed payload.

Rank	Codec	Total bytes	Median	Wins
1	ZX0 modern	190,037	24.24%	24
2	DAN2	190,348	24.38%	7
3	DAN1	190,707	24.52%	6
4	DAN3 Best	190,773	24.54%	9
5	MegaLZ	194,895	25.27%	0
6	aPLib Compact	195,679	24.95%	0
7	Pletter	195,925	25.24%	0
8	ZX7	195,946	25.23%	0
9	BitBuster	197,220	25.38%	0
10	ZX1	201,247	25.57%	0
11	ZX2	202,103	25.48%	0
12	LZF	220,059	29.37%	0
13	Nibble	240,948	35.48%	0
14	MDK-RLE	284,127	42.52%	0

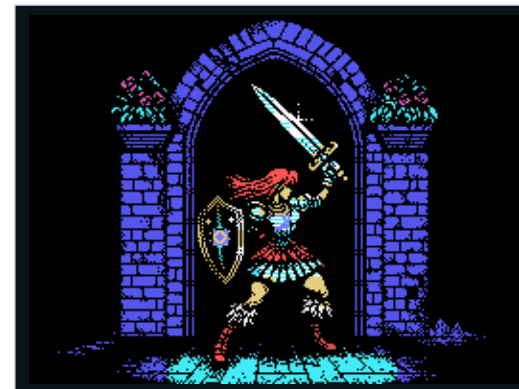
Corpus gallery 1-6



Cake
ZX0 modern - 24.07%



Commando
ZX0 modern - 43.21%



Warrior
ZX0 modern - 23.19%



Barbarian
ZX0 modern - 34.42%

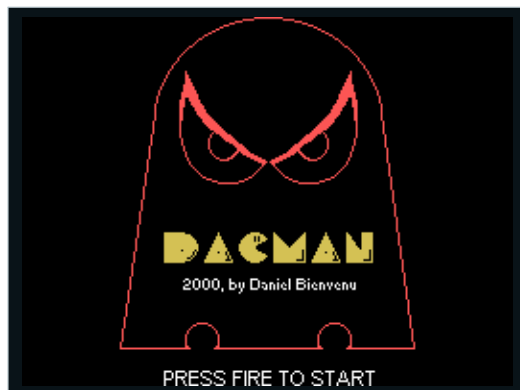


421 title
ZX0 modern - 8.59%

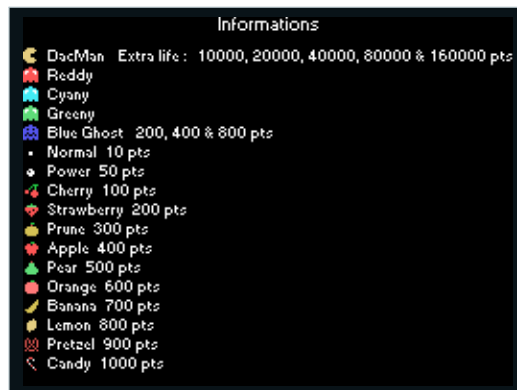


421 credits
ZX0 modern - 22.68%

Corpus gallery 7-12



Dacman title
DAN1 - 7.89%



Dacman info
ZX0 modern - 10.25%



Dacman 2 title
DAN2 - 9.51%



Chateau title
ZX0 modern - 13.31%

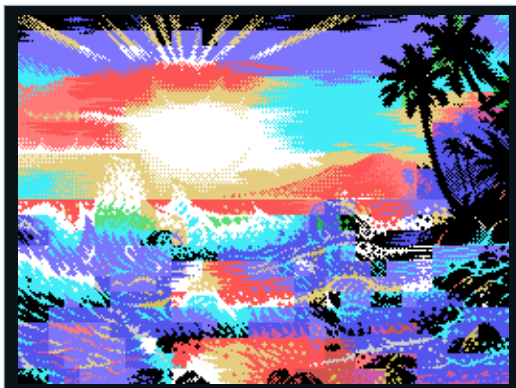


Arcade Trio title
DAN2 - 24.36%

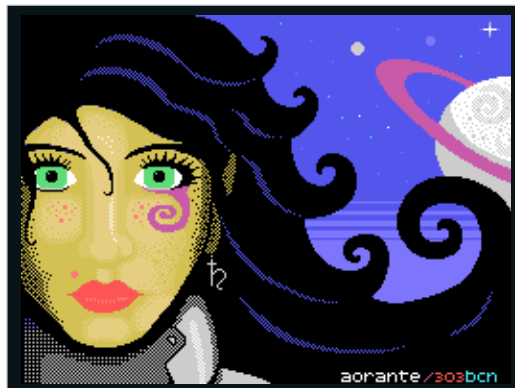


Almighty God - Aliquis Acuario Ingens
ZX0 modern - 58.87%

Corpus gallery 13-18



Aloha (ArtField 2010, 1)
DAN1 - 56.88%



Aorante - Lady Saturn
DAN3 Best - 29.73%



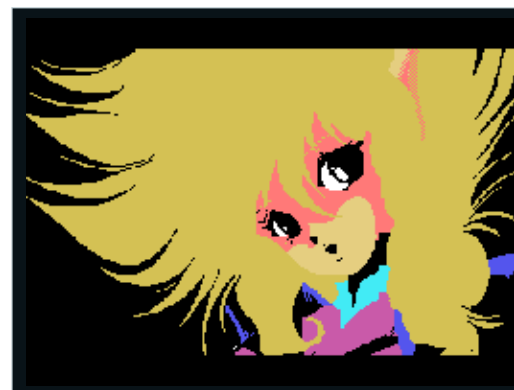
asian beauty 1
ZX0 modern - 64.55%



asian beauty 2
DAN2 - 77.95%



bejeweled title public.pp
ZX0 modern - 12.73%



benchmark-anime-portrait
DAN2 - 17.55%

Corpus gallery 19-24



benchmark-band-logo
ZX0 modern - 17.68%



benchmark-bat-character
ZX0 modern - 7.98%



benchmark-blue-portrait
ZX0 modern - 49.42%



benchmark-fantasy-camp
DAN2 - 49.95%



benchmark-feliz-navidad
DAN3 Best - 33.76%



benchmark-laser-squad
DAN2 - 60.94%

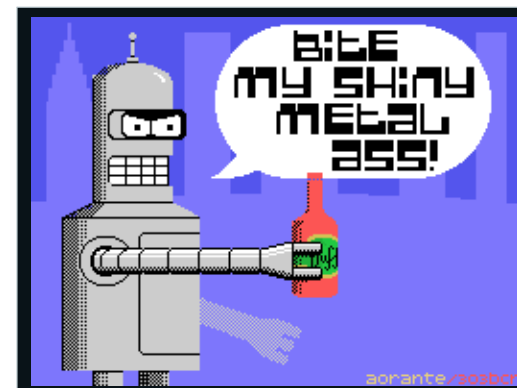
Corpus gallery 25-30



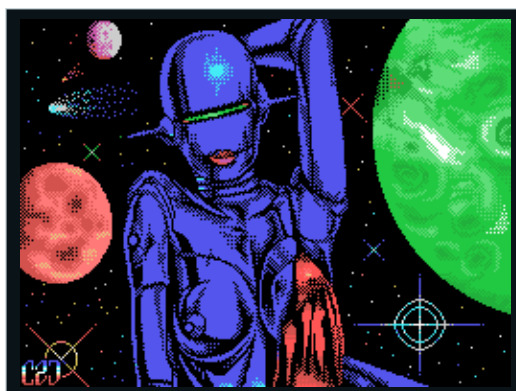
benchmark-mermaid-portrait
ZX0 modern - 49.24%



benchmark-reservoir-dogs
ZX0 modern - 18.84%



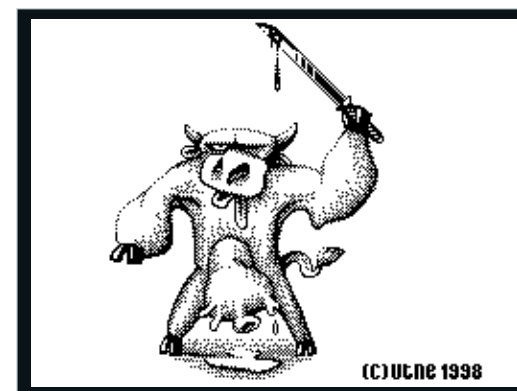
benchmark-robot-quote
DAN3 Best - 16.89%



benchmark-space-soldier
DAN2 - 45.97%

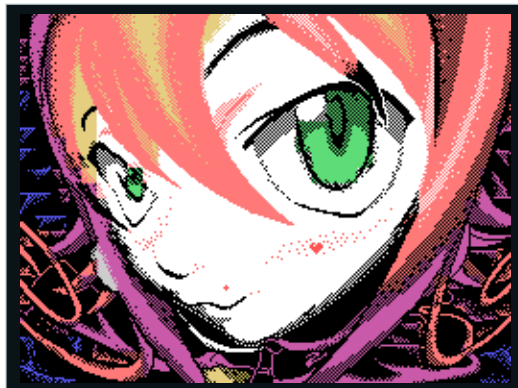


benchmark-turban-character
DAN1 - 64.36%



benchmark-wizard-sketch
DAN3 Best - 17.67%

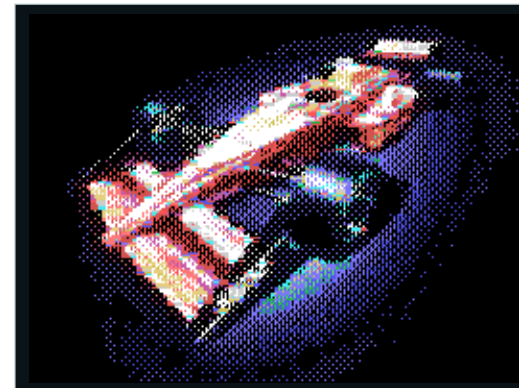
Corpus gallery 31-36



Blair (Chaos Constructions 2009, 6)
ZX0 modern - 43.72%



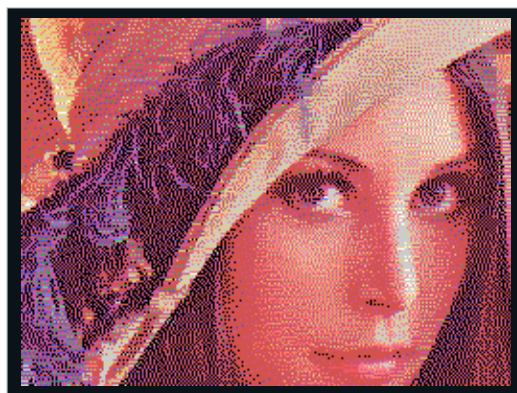
Bugs (Demobit 1995, 4)
DAN3 Best - 17.02%



f1spp
DAN3 Best - 34.81%



Kozmonaut (Forever 7, 7)
DAN3 Best - 22.62%



lenna
ZX0 modern - 76.50%



maze maniac.pp
DAN3 Best - 22.05%

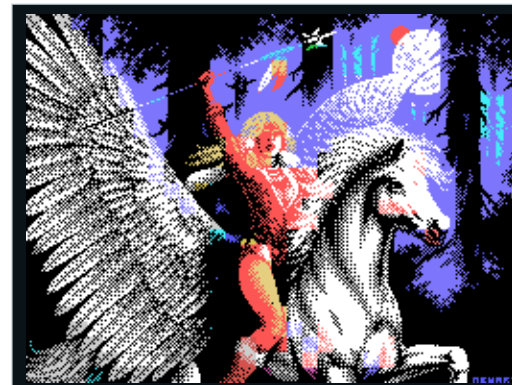
Corpus gallery 37-42



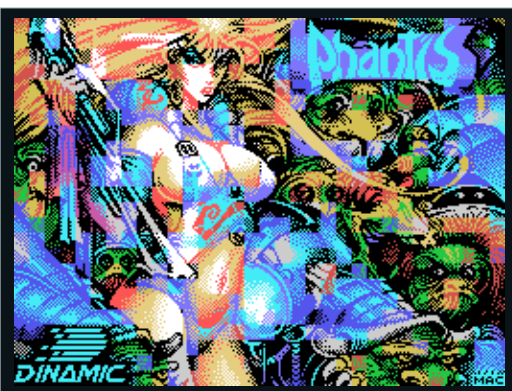
mona lisa
ZX0 modern - 76.71%



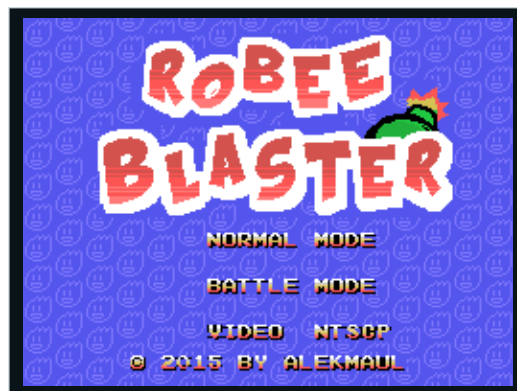
NewColeco ROM File Edition
ZX0 modern - 7.33%



Pegasus (Millennium 1903, 1)
ZX0 modern - 52.12%



Phantis (3BM OpenAir 2014, 1)
DAN1 - 68.25%

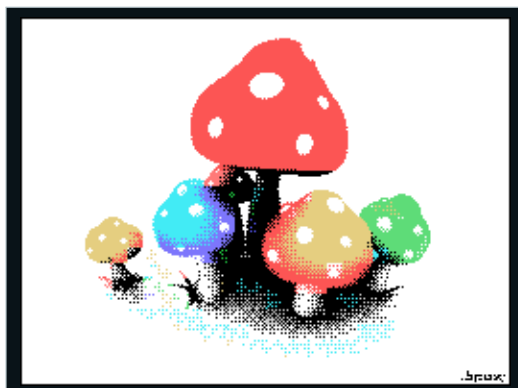


Robee Blaster title
ZX0 modern - 16.94%



smurf challenge
DAN1 - 10.29%

Corpus gallery 43-46



Stainly Rainbow (ArtField 2006, 3)
ZX0 modern - 18.29%



Vranov (Chaos Constructions 2001, 7)
ZX0 modern - 28.28%



Xzema (Chaos Constructions 2001, 2)
DAN1 - 55.32%



Znachok (Enlight 1996, 15)
DAN3 Best - 17.37%

Date: 2026-09-01

Method

This comparison separates four kinds of evidence:

- **Runtime verified:** compiled for ColecoVision and checked in an emulator or self-test.
- **Build verified:** the ColecoVision source, header, library, or generated assembly was inspected.
- **Documented:** claimed by the tool's official documentation, but not yet measured here.
- **Unverified:** available somewhere in the wider tool, but not proven for ColecoVision.

Amy Studio is both a language and an integrated development environment. The other entries are primarily compilers or C development kits. IDE-only capabilities are therefore listed separately instead of being treated as language features.

The seven solutions

Solution	Primary approach	ColecoVision position
Amy Studio	ColecoVision-first Amy language and browser IDE	Original 1 KB RAM, BIOS-aware, no extra hardware by design
CVBasic	Portable integer BASIC cross-compiler	Mature native target; optional MegaCart and SGM support
z88dk +coleco	General Z80 C toolchain	C compiler, assembler, linker, libraries, and app packaging
ugBASIC	Portable retro BASIC compiler	Declared target with common high-level multimedia vocabulary
devkitSMS + sglib_cv	SDCC C plus compact game libraries	ColecoVision adaptation of the SG/SMS development workflow
PVCoLib	ColecoVision-focused SDCC C library and devkit	Native VDP, controller, sprite, sound, music, and compression APIs
NewColeco	Historical SDCC C, CRTCV, CVLIB, and GETPUT 1.1	Amy's pre-Studio ColecoVision workflow and direct ancestor of current techniques

Reproducible four-sample ROM suite

The current suite builds four runnable programs with all seven solutions:

1. a visible Hello World;
2. the Warrior Graphics II bitmap picture;
3. a visual controller monitor;
4. an animated, controller-driven three-color metasprite.

A **metasprite** is one visual actor assembled from multiple hardware sprites. The benchmark overlaps three 16x16 TMS9918 sprites for white, yellow, and black layers, remaining below the four-sprites-per-scanline limit.

Run `tools/build-five-tool-bluemsx-suite.ps1`, `tools/build-pvcollib-benchmarks.ps1`, then `node tools/build-legacy-devkit-benchmarks.mjs` for the first three samples. Their 21 ROM files are written under `build/competition/bluemsx-sample-suite`, grouped by tool. The same directory receives `occupied-sizes.csv` from `tools/report-five-tool-sample-sizes.ps1`.

Run `tools/build-sprite-metasprite-benchmarks.ps1` for the seven sprite ROMs and their stricter GearColeco VRAM/SAT oracle.

Maximum native optimization used

Solution	Setting used	Observation
Amy Studio	Experimental	Saved 1 byte on Bitmap and 2 on Controller versus Balanced; Hello was unchanged
CVBasic 0.9.2	Normal compiler; TMSColor -z -p2 for Bitmap	No stronger compiler optimization switch was exposed; Pletter is used for its bitmap
z88dk	+co1eco -03; ZX0 for Bitmap	Coleco-safe direct-to-VRAM port of z88dk's ZX0 core; ZX7, MDKRLE, and raw baselines remain measured
ugBASIC 1.18	Default maximum of 16 peephole passes	Explicit 32- and 64-pass builds produced the same Hello binary
devkitSMS / SDCC 4.5	--opt-code-size --max-allocs-per-node 100000 on the program and SGLib	Saved 60 bytes on Bitmap; Hello and Controller were unchanged
PVCoLib 1.6.0 / bundled SDCC	--opt-code-size --max-allocs-per-node 20000	Official build flags; linked only referenced library modules
NewColeco / SDCC 3.8	--std-c99; original prebuilt libraries plus historical DAN2	The exact DAN2 bitmap is 626 bytes smaller than its GETPUT MDKRLE baseline

These are the strongest **native settings that were built and validated here**. Generated code was not passed through Amy's optimizer or MDL, because doing so would compare an additional external optimizer rather than each solution's normal output. Amy Experimental is appropriate for this maximum-size experiment; this table does not redefine Balanced as Amy's recommended default.

Real occupied size, excluding cartridge padding

Sample	Amy Studio	NewColeco	PVCoLib	devkitSMS	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC
Hello World	238	795	1,106	1,507	1,466	3,687	5,245
Warrior bitmap	3,254	3,643	4,525	4,713	4,948	4,976	18,034
Controller Visual	595	932	1,194	1,430	1,695	4,016	5,887
Sprite Metasprite	983	1,142	1,304	1,681	1,845	2,902	7,718
Four-sample total	5,087	6,512	8,129	9,331	9,954	15,581	36,884

The improved bitmap rows retain measured baselines: z88dk's raw-table ROM was 14,293 bytes, MDKRLE reduced it to 5,911 bytes, ZX7 to 5,115 bytes, and the validated ZX0 path to 4,976 bytes; the legacy devkit's GETPUT MDKRLE ROM was 4,269 bytes before DAN2 reduced it to 3,643. Both replacements reproduce the original pattern table, color table, and all 49,152 pixels exactly. The installed ugBASIC 1.18 Coleco target accepts **LOAD IMAGE ... COMPRESSED**, but Warrior produces the same 18,034-byte ROM and identical hash as **NONE**: MSC1 is discarded when it does not shrink the converted resource. The RLE image branch is compiled only for C128, not Coleco.

The exact legacy payload comparison is MDKRLE 3,687 bytes, DAN1 2,903, DAN2 2,897, and DAN3 2,891. DAN2 remains the linked benchmark: DAN3 saves only six payload bytes before decoder cost, while the historical DAN2 SDCC wrapper is already validated end to end.

Occupied includes the cartridge header, linked runtime, program code, and ROM data. It does not include the **\$00/\$FF** bytes added to reach an 8, 16, or 32 KB cartridge image. The report never guesses by removing repeated final bytes:

- Amy uses the assembled ROM length;
- CVBasic uses **ROM_END** - **\$8000** from the assembler listing;
- z88dk uses its unpadded linked binary;
- ugBASIC uses its generated code and data binaries;

- devkitSMS uses the occupied Intel HEX address span above **\$8000**.
- PVCoLib uses the occupied Intel HEX address span above **\$8000**.
- the legacy devkit uses the complete unpadding binary emitted from its Intel HEX link.

Runtime and comparability verdict

Sample	Runtime result	Verdict
Hello World	Seven ROMs complete 180 GearColeco frames	Stable startup
Warrior bitmap	Seven native pipelines render the same 256x192 image	0 / 49,152 pixels differ
Controller Visual	Six pass injected neutral, keypad, UP, FIRE, and release states	Partial: ugBASIC does not update VDP R7
Sprite Metasprite	Seven pass the same VRAM and sprite-table checks	Exact patterns, layers, and priority

PVCoLib and NewColeco use **\$F0** white-on-transparent text in the controller fixture instead of their customary **\$F1** white-on-black. This presentation-only normalization exposes the changing VDP R7 backdrop without changing controller logic or occupied size.

The bitmap test uses each tool's validated native workflow: Amy ZX0, CVBasic Pletter, z88dk ZX0, ugBASIC image resources, devkitSMS aPLib, PVCoLib RLE, and NewColeco DAN2. CVBasic's tables differ internally, but TMS9918 can encode the same pixels several ways. All seven framebuffers are exact. PVCoLib Pletter failed VRAM validation and is excluded; codec rankings use the separate payload test.

For z88dk, MDKRLE reaches VRAM at frame 93, ZX0 at 132, and ZX7 at 138. ZX0 saves 935 bytes over MDKRLE and 139 over ZX7; MDKRLE loads faster. A separate attempt to transplant the SMS aPLib decoder into the z88dk fixture failed exact VRAM validation and is excluded. The native devkitSMS aPLib fixture remains exact when frame interrupts are disabled during decompression.

The initial ugBASIC mismatch came from the wrong RGB palette. With its target palette, all four corpus pictures render exactly.

Graphics II bitmap compression corpus

The corpus contains 46 unique pictures. Each is 12,288 RAW bytes (6,144 Pattern + 6,144 Color). All 690 measured codec streams round-trip exactly. Ratios exclude decoder code because one routine can serve many assets.

Rank	Codec	Total bytes	Average ratio	Median ratio	Best-size pictures
1	ZX0 modern	190,037	33.62%	24.24%	24
2	DAN2	190,348	33.68%	24.38%	7
3	DAN1	190,707	33.74%	24.52%	6
4	DAN3 Best	190,773	33.75%	24.54%	9
5	MegaLZ	194,895	34.48%	25.27%	0
6	aPLib Compact	195,679	34.62%	24.95%	0
7	Pletter	195,925	34.66%	25.24%	0
8	ZX7	195,946	34.67%	25.23%	0
9	BitBuster	197,220	34.89%	25.38%	0
10	ZX1	201,247	35.60%	25.57%	0
11	ZX2	202,103	35.75%	25.48%	0
12	LZF	220,059	38.93%	29.37%	0

Rank	Codec	Total bytes	Average ratio	Median ratio	Best-size pictures
13	Nibble	240,948	42.63%	35.48%	0
14	MDK-RLE	284,127	50.27%	42.52%	0

The three website representatives are selected mechanically from each picture's best payload ratio:

Role	Picture	Best ratio
most compressible	NewColeco ROM File Edition	7.33%
median	Arcade Trio title	24.36%
least compressible	asian beauty 2	77.95%

The PDF shows every converted image. Complete per-picture ratios, decoder sizes, first-use totals, and exact source values are in `competition/benchmarks/compression/bitmap-codec-ratios.csv`, `bitmap-codec-aggregate.csv`, and `bitmap-codec-first-use.csv`.

Observations supported by this suite

- Amy has the smallest Hello and controller-monitor footprint because its Coleco BIOS-aware runtime is selected from actual source capabilities.
- Amy wins this exact full-picture ROM measurement. CVBasic's internally different TMS9918 tables render the same pixels, but its Pletter streams and larger runtime produce a 4,948-byte result versus Amy's 3,254 bytes.
- General C/BASIC portability runtimes have a visible fixed cost on tiny programs; this does not prove they remain proportionally larger in complete games.
- Cartridge file length is packaging evidence, not occupied-code evidence. A 32 KB z88dk file is not automatically a 32 KB program.
- Optimization claims require runtime validation. A smaller file without matching behavior is rejected rather than counted as a win.
- Four samples are insufficient to declare one compiler universally smaller or faster. RAM, worst-frame cycles, build latency, sound behavior, sprite pressure, and gameplay logic remain separate measurements.

Preliminary capability matrix

Legend: **Yes** = verified or explicit target support; **Partial** = manual or narrower support; **Pending** = must still be proven specifically on ColecoVision. * marks a benchmark adaptation written here, not a native ColecoVision direct-to-VRAM path supplied by that solution.

Capability	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	devkitSMS / SGLib_CV	PVCoLib
8/16-bit integers	Yes	Yes	Yes	Documented	Yes, through SDCC	Yes, through SDCC
32-bit integers	Yes, runtime tested	No native BASIC type	Yes	Documented; target cost pending	Yes, through SDCC	Yes, through SDCC

Capability	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	devkitSMS / SGLib_CV	PVCoLib
Fixed-point	Yes, 8.8 and 16.16	No	Library/manual	Documented; target proof pending	Manual C/library code	Manual C/library code
Records/structures	Yes	No	Yes	Documented custom types	Yes	Yes
2D arrays	Yes	No native 2D syntax	Yes	Documented	Yes	Yes
RAM overlays	Yes, first-class	Manual	C union/manual layout	Pending	C union/manual layout	C union/manual layout
Functions with values and returns	Yes	Limited BASIC procedures/DEF FN	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Inline Z80 assembly	Yes	Yes	Yes	Documented	Yes	Yes
TMS9918 screen and tile operations	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes, target proof incomplete	Yes	Yes
Hardware sprite API	Yes	Yes	Low-level/library	Yes, exact target surface pending	Yes	Yes, 32-entry SAT
Four-sprite scanline mitigation	Yes, stable ranges and flicker	Yes, sprite flicker	Manual	Pending	Manual/library-dependent	Yes, NMI sprite swapping
Keypad	Yes	Yes	Library/manual	Pending	Yes/target library	Yes, both ports
Spinner / Roller Controller	Yes	Yes	Not confirmed	Pending	Not confirmed	Yes, both ports
Held, pressed, and released input	Yes	Held; edges are manual	Manual	Manual edges over JOY	Yes, computed from NMI snapshots	Manual edges over NMI snapshots
Coleco PSG sound	BIOS tables, Tiny Sound, DSOUND	Sound/music commands	Sound libraries	Sound commands, target proof pending	PSGLib_CV	BIOS-style sound tables and sequenced music
Direct-to-VRAM compression	Thirteen active codecs; ZX0 Classic measured separately	Pletter	RAM APIs; ZX0, ZX1, ZX2, and ZX7 benchmark VRAM ports	Resource conversion; RAM-oriented compression	ZX7 and aPLib	RLE, Pletter, DAN1/2/3
ROM banking	Intentionally no	Yes	Yes	Pending	SMS workflow has banking; CV support pending	MegaCart tools and examples
Source-level Coleco debugger	Integrated	External emulator	External debugger/emulator	External or IDE-dependent	External debugger/emulator	External debugger/emulator
Rewind, breakpoints, VRAM/RAM inspection	Integrated	External	External	External	External	External
Graphics editors and project assets	Integrated	Separate tools	Separate tools	Conversion-oriented IDE/tools	Separate asset tools	gfx2co1 and separate asset tools
Automated ROM behavior tests	Integrated project pipeline	Not supplied as one system	Can be assembled manually	Not established	Not established	Not established

Detailed language and runtime evidence

Data model

Area	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	devkitSMS	PVCoLib
Integer widths	Explicit signed/unsigned 8/16/32	8/16, signed or unsigned	C 8/16/32	Backend defines signed/unsigned 8/16/32	SDCC C 8/16/32	SDCC C 8/16/32
Fractional math	fixed , ufixed , fixed32 , fp5	None	C/library float and fixed libraries	VT_FLOAT exists; Coleco cost pending	SDCC float/manual fixed	SDCC float/manual fixed
Decimal scores	Packed BCD 1-12 digits	Manual	Manual/library	Manual	Manual/library	Manual/library

Area	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	devkitSMS	PVCoLib
Aggregates	Nested records, record arrays	None	struct/union	Typed arrays and internal resource types; user-structure surface pending	struct/union	struct/union
Multidimensional arrays	Primitive 2D arrays	One-dimensional only	Native C	Typed arrays; dimensional coverage pending	Native C	Native C
Mutually exclusive RAM	First-class overlays/scenes	Manual aliases	union/linker/manual	Banking/resource allocator; no equivalent proven	union/linker/manual	union/linker/manual
Dynamic strings	Deliberately fixed-buffer oriented	Mostly literals/printing	C strings and allocation libraries	First-class strings	C strings; risky in 1 KB RAM	C strings; risky in 1 KB RAM

Amy's data model is the most game-oriented for stock ColecoVision RAM. C remains the most general, but generality does not provide automatic lifetime analysis or a debugger-aware overlay. ugBASIC has a broad internal type system; its actual ColecoVision ROM/RAM cost still requires compilation.

Control, timing, and code organization

Area	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	devkitSMS	PVCoLib
Procedures/functions	Typed values, ref , returns, recursion	Procedures without value parameters; DEF FN expression macros	Full C	Procedures/functions documented	Full C	Full C
State machines	Typed zero-RAM dispatch	Manual SELECT /labels	Manual enum/switch/table	Manual control constructs	Manual enum/switch/table	Manual enum/switch/table
VBlank	wait , frame hooks, timers	WAIT, ON FRAME	HALT/NMI hooks/manual	WAIT VBL, EVERY , timers	SG_waitForVBlank , frame handler	vdp_waitvblank , user nmi hook
Parallel animation	Not yet first-class	Manual	Manual/interrupt	ANIMATION, ANIMATE, MOVE , paths and multitasking source present	Manual frame service	Manual NMI/frame service
Inline assembly	Amy ASM bridge	ASM, CALL, USR	Native inline/external ASM	Supported	SDCC inline/external ASM	SDCC inline/external ASM

ugBASIC is the strongest source of ideas for a future optional Amy animation service. It also shows the risk: animations create state variables, thread handles, paths, delays, signals, and background-preservation storage. Amy should not copy that surface until exact RAM and cycle costs are visible and the entire service disappears when unused.

TMS9918 graphics and sprites

Area	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	SGlib_CV	PVCoLib
Text/tile/bitmap modes	Coleco-specific commands and editors	Modes and direct VRAM commands	Generic TMS9918/graphics libraries	TMS9918 backend and resource conversion	Tile, bitmap, VDP and VRAM functions	Text, bitmap, VDP and VRAM functions
Pixel/line/circle	Yes, programmer controls NMI-safe batching	Yes	Generic graphics	TMS9918 drawing backend	Pixel/bitmap helpers	Low-level VRAM/bitmap support
Sprites	Fields, clipping helpers, movement, editor	Define/place sprites	Low-level/library	Sprite conversion and TMS9918 operations	SAT builder, clipping, finalize/copy	32-entry SAT, update and fast-update APIs
Collision	Hitboxes, tile groups, hardware status	VDP status/manual	Hardware/manual	Hardware collision/hit backend	VDP status/manual	spr_collide hitboxes and VDP status
Scanline overflow	Explicit flicker and stable priority ranges	Sprite flicker	Manual	No verified policy	Manual ordering	spr_getentry swaps sprites each NMI
Asset authoring	Integrated bitmap/tile/sprite/frame editors	Separate tools	Separate tools	Automatic image conversion	External asset tools	gfx2co1 and external tools

Amy's lead is the complete authoring/debugging workflow and explicit TMS9918 policy. ugBASIC's automatic modern-image conversion is substantial, while SGLib_CV offers a compact C SAT workflow.

Controllers

Capability	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	SGLib_CV	PVCoLib
Two directions/fire ports	Yes	Yes	joystick(1/2)	JOY(0/1) backend	NMI snapshots both ports	joypad_1/2, four fire bits
Two keypad ports	Yes	Yes	joystick(3/4) high byte	SCANCODE path; exact port behavior pending	SG_readCVNumPad	keypad_1/2
Pressed/released	First-class per property	Manual previous state	Manual previous state	Manual previous state	First-class status helpers	Manual previous-state comparison
Spinner/Roller	Yes	Yes	Not found in Coleco target	Not found yet	Not found	spinner_1/2, reset and enable APIs
Automatic minimal backend	Yes, capability selected	Runtime-integrated	Linker includes referenced routines	Deployment system includes used modules	Library/NMI input service	Linker extracts referenced modules

Sound and music

Area	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	devkitSMS	PVCoLib
SN76489 tones/noise	BIOS sound tables and direct formats	SOUND	PSG libraries/manual ports	SN76489 backend	PSGLib_CV	BIOS-style sound tables
Sequenced music	BIOS format and Tiny Sound	MUSIC, simple/full players	External/player libraries	MUSIC backend	PSG streams; looping/status	NMI-serviced music sequences
Concurrent SFX	Coleco table areas/Tiny Sound	Channel depends on music mode	Library-dependent	Pending measurement	PSG SFX channels and frame service	Four music areas plus sound areas 5+ for SFX
Digital samples	DSOUND	No first-class support	Manual/custom	Pending	No first-class support found	No first-class support found
Authoring	Integrated table inspector, tone preview, echo-tail builder, MIDI capture; full sequence editing pending	Note-oriented BASIC source	External VGM/tools	Source/resource conversion	External PSG tools	External table/asset tools

Amy has the broadest playback formats, while CVBasic keeps the simplest music source syntax. Amy Studio can now inspect existing BIOS tables, preview generated commands, audition steady/fade/ echo envelopes, and capture note, velocity, and duration from Web MIDI. The remaining authoring gap is a complete multi-command sequence editor with byte-exact source/project write-back.

Compression evidence

Compression must be scored as **compressed payload + linked decompressor**, with destination and cycles. Counting a host compressor without a ColecoVision decoder is invalid.

All thirteen integrated Amy codecs were also compiled as separate Balanced ROMs and run for 180 NTSC frames in GearColeco. Every ROM reproduced Warrior's 6,144 Pattern bytes and 6,144 Color bytes exactly in VRAM. Run **node tools/test-integrated-codec-vram-roms.mjs** to repeat this check.

Solution	Confirmed formats	Direct VRAM status	Integrated selection
Amy Studio	ZX0, ZX1, ZX2, aPLib, ZX7, Pletter, DAN1/2/3, LZF, BitBuster, MDK-RLE, Nibble	ColecoVision paths, including workspace-based formats	Browser comparison/import and asset metadata
CVBasic	Pletter	DEFINE CHAR/COLOR/SPRITE/VRAM PLETTER	Explicit source keyword

Solution	Confirmed formats	Direct VRAM status	Integrated selection
z88dk	ZX0/1/2/7 and aPLib families, multiple speed/size decoders	Stock decoders target RAM; ZX0 and ZX7 Coleco VRAM adaptations verified here	Manual headers/linking and host tools
ugBASIC	MSC1 and RLE types in compiler source	MSC1 image fallback verified; RLE is not implemented for Coleco	Resource compiler can choose compression when it wins
SGlib_CV / SMSlib routine	ZX7 and aPLib	ZX7 API; aPLib direct-to-VRAM exact with frame IRQ disabled	Manual host compression and C asset inclusion
PVColLib	RLE, Pletter, DAN1/2/3	RLE direct-to-VRAM verified exactly here; other paths remain separate candidates	gfx2col conversion and C asset inclusion
NewColeco	GETPUT 1.1 MDK-RLE	Direct-to-VRAM verified exactly on Warrior	External CVPaint/asset tools and C data inclusion

z88dk's public ZX0 integration request dates from February 2021, consistent with ZX0/ZX7 being available there by spring 2021. Its bundled compressor identifies itself as ZX0 v1.5 and emits the official classic v1 format. Amy Studio's current **zx0** codec emits the later official v2 format by default. The streams are intentionally not interchangeable. z88dk's stock routines target RAM; this benchmark adds only ColecoVision TMS9918 direct-to-VRAM adaptations and validates their output independently.

Codec naming and integration policy

Candidate	Honest Amy name	Current evidence	Integration condition
ZX0 modern	ZX0 / codec zx0	Existing v2 browser encoder and Coleco VRAM decoder	Keep as the default
ZX0 classic	ZX0 Classic (v1) / proposed codec zx0v1	z88dk v1.5 compressor plus exact benchmark VRAM port	Explicit extension and cross-format rejection tests
ZX1	ZX1 / codec zx1	Byte-identical browser encoder; exact four-picture GearColeco VRAM proof	Integrated; measure Coleco cycle cost
ZX2	ZX2 / codec zx2	Byte-identical browser encoder; exact eleven-picture round-trip and five-profile GearColeco VRAM proof	Integrated; measure Coleco cycle cost
aPLib	aPLib / codec aplib	Bidirectional appack parity and exact Amy/GearColeco VRAM ROM	Integrated; keep NMI-safe upload and attribution explicit
MSC1	MSC1	ugBASIC discards it for Warrior when it gives no gain	Useful Coleco corpus wins and a VRAM strategy

A host compressor alone is insufficient. An Amy codec requires round-trip tests, exact GearColeco VRAM output, decoder cost, explicit destination semantics, malformed-stream failure tests, documentation, and attribution. RAM-only APIs and locally written VRAM ports must remain labelled.

Current verdict: Amy leads in codec breadth and ColecoVision workflow; devkitSMS has verified ZX7 and aPLib paths, PVColLib has a verified RLE path, and CVBasic has a concise Pletter path. On Warrior and Cake, official ZX1, ZX2, and aPLib do not beat Amy's ZX0 first-use ROM size. aPLib nevertheless cuts the devkitSMS Warrior ROM from 13,680 raw bytes to 4,713 occupied bytes. ZX1 is now an integrated Amy codec with a 127-byte direct-to-VRAM decoder and exact Cake, Commando, Warrior, and Barbarian runtime proofs. Its remaining question is measured cycle cost. ugBASIC's MSC1 is a valid comparison candidate, not ten separate codecs, but it does not improve the Warrior resource.

What MSC1 actually is

MSC1 is ugBASIC's compact block-repetition format, not another general ZX0-style LZ codec. A stream contains literal blocks of 1-127 bytes and back-references that repeat one four-byte sequence up to 32 times. The back-reference offset is limited to roughly 1 KB, and a zero token ends the stream. This favors maps, records, planar graphics, and other data with repeated groups of four bytes.

The current Z80 decoder is simple and Apache-2.0 licensed, but writes to ordinary memory with **LD (DE), A**. On a stock 1 KB ColecoVision it cannot directly expand a 6 KB pattern or color table. More importantly, ugBASIC's generic **LOAD("file") COMPRESSED** implementation only invokes MSC1 when the target declares expansion banks. The standard Coleco

target does not, so the keyword is accepted but ignored there. Five raw/compressed resource pairs produced byte-identical generated code and data. This is therefore not presently a general Coleco capability comparable to Amy's direct-to-VRAM codecs.

MSC1 can still be selected by some ugBASIC image/resource conversion paths. A fair evaluation of that narrower feature needs a direct-to-VRAM proof and a mixed corpus: bitmap tables, name tables, tile sets, sprite frames, level maps, record arrays, and sound data. Only candidates that reduce **payload + linked decoder**, round-trip exactly, and pass GearColeco should be added.

aPLib integration status

aPLib has three useful pieces already available locally: the official host compressor, Amy's JavaScript beam-search encoder, and direct-to-VRAM Z80 implementations in z88dk/devkitSMS. The devkitSMS routine uses the Coleco-compatible **\$BF/\$BE** VDP ports, but is explicitly unsafe while the display is active and lacks the Coleco BIOS protection used by **SG_decompressZX7toVRAM**.

The JavaScript encoder now passes bidirectional differential checks against official aPLib on real TMS9918 tables and structured, incompressible, repetitive, short, and boundary-sized data. Its exact-cost planner produces 3,054 bytes for Cake and 2,973 for Warrior, versus official raw payloads of 3,088 and 2,975. Official **appack** still wins some individual resources, so neither encoder universally dominates.

Amy now ships the browser encoder and a 244-byte compact public-domain SMSlib-derived ColecoVision VRAM decoder. **decompress aplib Source to vram.pattern** accepts a raw **.aplib** stream and the existing VRAM upload wrapper provides the same NMI-safe contract as other Amy LZ codecs. A compiled Amy ROM reconstructed Warrior's 6,144-byte pattern and color tables exactly in GearColeco under all five optimization profiles. The Balanced test ROM occupied 3,517 bytes with 2,973 compressed data bytes. The official aPLib executable is used only for differential testing and is not redistributed.

The first reproducible size results and the rules for the cross-tool runtime comparison are in **competition/benchmarks/compression/README.md**. On two real 12,288-byte TMS9918 pictures, ZX0 has the smallest Amy first-use ROM total after its current 133-byte decompressor estimate is included. This is a size result, not a speed verdict; Z80 cycle measurements remain required.

Memory, ROM size, and banking

Area	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	devkitSMS	PVCoLib
Stock 1 KB RAM focus	Core design, RAM estimates, overlays	Yes, global/static model	Configurable CRT/C runtime	Backend manages runtime/resources	SDCC/static library model	SDCC/static library model
Dead helper elimination	Capability-driven generation	Compiler-generated runtime	Linker sections/libraries	Deploy-on-use modules and target optimizer	Linker library extraction	Linker library extraction
Optimizer	Five profiles plus runtime corpus	Z80 optimizer and peepholes	sccz80/zsdcc optimizers	Coleco-specific optimizer source	SDCC optimizer/peepholes	SDCC size optimization
Beyond 32 KB	Deliberately excluded	MegaCart up to 1 MB	Coleco banking/toolchain	Target support not yet proven	MegaCart and banked functions documented	MegaCart tools and example verified
Debug-aware RAM names	Yes, including overlay aliases	Assembly labels	Map/debug symbols	Generated symbols	Map symbols	Map symbols

Banking is a capability advantage for CVBasic, z88dk, and devkitSMS, but not a feature Amy intends to adopt: Amy explicitly preserves the original unexpanded-hardware philosophy. The comparison should describe this limitation honestly without turning it into a roadmap requirement.

Stock baseline versus expanded hardware

The size and runtime ranking above targets an original ColecoVision: TMS9918A video, SN76489 sound, 1 KB system RAM, Coleco BIOS, and an unbanked cartridge whenever possible. Optional hardware is credited separately because it changes the machine available to the programmer:

Extension	Verified or documented advantage	Scope in this comparison
MegaCart / bank switching	CVBasic, z88dk, devkitSMS, and PVCoLib can exceed the normal cartridge space	Valid capability; excluded from stock-ROM size ranking
F18A	PVCoLib provides dedicated APIs and examples for enhanced video hardware	Valid for modified or compatible clone systems; out of scope for ColecoVision-exclusive titles
SGM / AY-3-8910-compatible sound	CVBasic and PVCoLib provide explicit SGM paths; PVCoLib also detects SGM RAM and ADAM	Valid expansion/clone capability; out of scope for the stock sound ranking
Extra RAM	Available through SGM, ADAM, and compatible clones depending on the tool/runtime	Report separately; never count it as stock 1 KB RAM

This separation lets every solution show its extended-hardware strengths without weakening Amy Studio's deliberate original-hardware target.

Development experience

Area	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	devkitSMS	PVCoLib
Browser IDE	Integrated	No official integrated IDE	No	IDE/web options advertised	No	No
Source breakpoints	Yes	External emulator	External debugger	IDE-dependent/unverified	External emulator	External emulator
ASM stepping/rewind	Integrated GearColeco workflow	External	External	External	External	External
RAM/VRAM/symbol inspection	Integrated	External	External	External	External	External/map symbols
Cycle profiling	Integrated	External/manual	External/manual	Unverified	External/manual	External/manual
Project graphics editors	Integrated/configurable	Separate tools	Separate tools	Resource conversion/IDE	Separate tools	gfx2col/separate tools
Automated ROM tests	Corpus, checkpoints, runtime harness	Not integrated	Buildable manually	Not established	Not established	Not established

This is Amy Studio's decisive advantage. A fair comparison should still label command-line-only Amy scripts separately from features directly accessible in the IDE.

Amy Studio leads in ColecoVision integration

Amy's strongest distinction is not one isolated keyword. It connects source editing, asset conversion, compression, assembly optimization, ROM execution, source breakpoints, rewind, memory and VRAM inspection, controller configuration, profiling, and automated tests in one ColecoVision-focused workflow. Its overlays, typed state machines, BCD, fixed-point support, runtime-checked wide integers, collision helpers, and BIOS-aware input selection are also substantial language-level strengths.

CVBasic leads in portability and established BASIC simplicity

CVBasic has a compact QBasic-like surface, a mature ColecoVision backend, many complete game examples, spinner support, sprite flicker support, music commands, and optional ROM banking. It also targets many related machines. It does not offer Amy's records, overlays, wide numeric model, integrated debugger, or asset/debug pipeline.

Official source: [nanochess/CVBasic](https://github.com/nanochess/CVBasic)

z88dk leads in general C and toolchain breadth

z88dk provides full C data structures, pointers, mature compilers, assemblers, linkers, libraries, compression utilities, and many Z80 targets. This flexibility also exposes more low-level choices to the programmer. Its generic graphics or library facilities must not be mistaken for an Amy-style ColecoVision game API without target-specific proof.

Official source: [z88dk/z88dk](https://github.com/z88dk/z88dk)

ugBASIC has the most ambitious portable high-level vocabulary

ugBASIC documents nonblocking animation, movement, paths, image conversion, sprites, sound, and many modern BASIC constructs. This makes it especially relevant when considering future Amy animation ergonomics. However, its multi-target manual describes capabilities that can differ by backend. Generated ColecoVision Z80 and runtime behavior must be measured before declaring those features equivalent.

Official sources: [ugBASIC site](https://ugbasic.iwashere.eu/) and [spotlessmind1975/ugbasic](https://github.com/spotlessmind1975/ugbasic)

devkitSMS offers a compact C game-library workflow

devkitSMS combines SDCC with small game-oriented libraries and asset tools. **SGLib_CV** and **PSGLib_CV** make it relevant to ColecoVision even though much of the surrounding documentation is SMS-oriented. Only APIs present in the CV headers and libraries should enter the final score.

The local **SGLib_CV** source confirms that its ColecoVision NMI scans direction/fire mode and numpad/right-trigger mode, preserves current and previous states, and implements **SG_getKeysStatus**, **SG_getKeysPressed**, **SG_getKeysHeld**, **SG_getKeysReleased**, and **SG_readCVNumPad**. These input capabilities are source-verified for ColecoVision, not inferred from SMSlib.

Official source: [sverx/devkitSMS](https://github.com/sverx/devkitSMS)

PVColLib offers broad ColecoVision-focused C APIs

PVColLib is a ColecoVision-focused SDCC library and development kit. Its official repository includes the compiler toolchain, VDP and controller APIs, sprites, sound/music support, compression routines, MegaCart, SGM, Phoenix, and F18A facilities. The three stock fixtures here use its official build flags and linked library. Local headers and examples verify both controller ports and keypads, both spinners, 32 sprites, NMI sprite swapping, hitbox collisions, BIOS-style sound tables, sequenced music with concurrent SFX areas, direct VRAM operations, MegaCart, SGM, Phoenix, and F18A support. Its RLE bitmap path was validated byte-for-byte in VRAM; the available Pletter and DAN paths are not credited with a benchmark size until a compatible stream passes the same exact runtime test.

Official source: [alekmaul/pvcollib](https://github.com/alekmaul/pvcollib)

NewColeco remains a strong historical baseline

The recovered SDCC branch uses Amy's original **CRTCv**, **CVLIB**, and GETPUT 1.1 libraries. Its prebuilt ASxxxx objects link successfully with the locally available SDCC 3.8 toolchain after using the modern `.rel` extension; no ABI or library source change was required. The three new fixtures complete 180 NTSC frames in GearColeco. Warrior is decompressed directly to VRAM with GETPUT's MDK-RLE routine and matches all 12,288 target table bytes and all 49,152 pixels.

This is not an unrelated seventh competitor: it is the documented historical ancestor of Amy Studio. Its 795-byte Hello, 3,643-byte DAN2 bitmap, and 932-byte controller monitor show that the old BIOS-aware and link-only-what-is-used philosophy was already effective. Amy Studio improves those results while adding the Amy language, integrated assets, diagnostics, and debugging.

Next measurement suite

The comparison becomes stronger as equivalent game behaviors are implemented seven times. Current status and order:

1. **Controller snapshot: built, semantic injection pending.** Inject directions, both fire buttons, keypad, press, hold, and release; assert the result bytes instead of only booting.
2. **Sprite/metasp Sprite stress: complete.** Seven toolchains build and boot the shared fixture.

Amy's native metasp Sprite path is runtime-equivalent, uses zero permanent RAM, preserves explicit layer priority, and is smaller than the manual renderer in all five profiles.

3. **Tile animation: next.** Update a small Graphics II region every frame without corruption and

measure VRAM bytes per frame.

- 4. **State update.** Run an actor array, collision checks, timers, and state dispatch.
- 5. **Sound authoring: command layer complete; sequence layer pending.** The inspector, audition, echo-tail builder, and Web MIDI capture are tested. Next, edit, loop, stop, switch, and write complete ColecoVision PSG sequences without changing table indices or shared tails.
- 6. **Compression: payload sizes measured; cycle suite pending.** Compare identical pattern/color/name data including linked decoder bytes, destination, and cycles.
- 7. **Visible Hello: complete.** Keep it separate from the minimal runtime fixture so font/text costs remain explicit.

The first fixture is now in **competition/benchmarks/controller-input**. Initial build facts:

- Amy: Off 413, Safe 409, Balanced 408, Aggressive 408, and Experimental 406 ROM bytes. The fixture has five explicit result bytes plus Amy's selected runtime state. All controller capabilities are selected from actual source usage. Runtime input injection is still required before these five builds receive the stronger runtime-verified status.
- z88dk +coleco -02: 2,117 bytes of useful binary before its cartridge image is padded to 32,768 bytes. Its CRT/BSS map reaches **\$717A**; the five result bytes occupy **\$701F-\$7023**.
- CVBasic, ugBASIC, and devkitSMS are now locally built and measured below.

Controller fixture ROM results

The build keeps all five ROMs under **build/competition/controller-input/** so they can be loaded manually in Amy Studio ROM TEST & DEBUG or another ColecoVision emulator.

Tool	Occupied ROM	ROM file	Entry	GearColeco
Amy Studio Balanced	408	408	\$8120	120-frame boot PASS
devkitSMS / SDCC 4.5	1,337	16,384	\$8024	120-frame boot PASS
CVBasic 0.9.2	1,483	8,192	\$853D	120-frame boot PASS
z88dk +coleco -02	2,117	32,768	\$802A	120-frame boot PASS
ugBASIC 1.18	5,337	16,384	\$82BF	120-frame boot PASS

Occupied ROM compares compiler and runtime output. **ROM file** is the downloadable file size and includes each toolchain's padding. CVBasic is measured from **ROM_END**, z88dk from its unpadded linked binary, ugBASIC from its code and data binaries, and devkitSMS from its Intel HEX span. The measurement never guesses by trimming trailing **\$00** or **\$FF** bytes.

The current GearColeco result proves deterministic startup and 120 completed frames, not yet equivalent controller semantics. Controlled input injection and assertions on all five result bytes are the next required QA stage.

For every fixture record source lines, compiler version, build time, ROM bytes, permanent RAM, worst-frame cycles, and runtime result. A smaller ROM that fails visually or changes behavior is not an optimization win.

Ranked Amy gap plan

Rank	Work	Value	Effort	Risk	Decision gate
1	Complete BIOS/Tiny Sound sequence authoring	High	Medium-large	Medium	Byte-exact write-back, stable indices/shared tails, and ROM/audio runtime proof
2	Controller semantic injection	High	Medium	Low	Assert neutral, direction, keypad, press, hold, release, and both fire buttons in every fixture
3	Seven-tool tile-animation benchmark	High	Medium	Low	Equivalent Graphics II workload, VRAM bytes/frame, cycles, and corruption oracle
4	Compression cycle benchmark	Medium	Medium	Low	Measure ColecoVision decoder cycles in addition to payload + decoder bytes
5	Small explicit animation service	High	Large	Medium-high	Add only after benchmark evidence; zero linked cost when unused and visible RAM/cycle budget
6	Nested aggregate 2D fields and final operand symmetry	Medium	Medium	Medium	Direct record/overlay 2D fields already pass; add nesting only for a real game need

Completed gaps and next concrete work

Completed and runtime-guarded:

- the seven-tool sprite/metasp Sprite fixture and shared GearColeco SAT oracle;
- native `data ... metasprite layers N` and `set metasprite ...`, with zero permanent RAM and

savings of **33**, **33**, **18**, **17**, and **17** bytes versus explicit rendering in the five profiles;

- stable sprite ranges and flicker with protected high-priority sprites;
- direct primitive 2D fields in records and overlay parts, verified in all five profiles;
- ZX1 direct-to-VRAM with exact four-picture GearColeco VRAM proof;
- Studio BIOS table inspection, command listening, compact echo-tail generation, and Web MIDI

note/velocity/duration capture.

Next concrete work is the **sound sequence editor**. It must turn the tested command layer into a multi-command timeline, preserve table slot numbers and shared-tail labels, preview area priority, and write byte-exact Amy/project data. Acceptance requires parser round trips, synthesized audio checks, and a GearColeco ROM proving start, loop, switch, stop, and concurrent SFX behavior. After that, finish controller input injection and build the tile-animation fixture before designing a general animation service.